It’s a dilemma I have wrestled with for years. Most news channels have dozens of reporters in Delhi but just one for the entire seven states of the north-east. In states like Jharkhand and Chhattisgarh, we rely on a stringer network. Naturally, news becomes metro-centric, with vast areas of the country going uncovered. On any given day, stories from Delhi occupy more than half the news space. We cover Ranchi when Dhoni reaches home; only a major Naxal attack takes us to a Raipur. The business model of modern television is our lamentable excuse. We are simply not willing to invest in building a strong national network.

The media-savvy Kejriwal knew this and exploited the situation to the hilt. Everything he said or did became a live news event. When he attempted a Janata Durbar (public hearing), there was a near stampede. When he decided to provide free water and subsidized power to specific income groups, it set off a raging debate. When he invited people to ‘sting’ government officials, it generated even more controversy. And when a minister in his government, Somnath Bharti, went on a midnight raid at the homes of African nationals accused of drug and sex trafficking, he was accused of ‘racism’.

The first major turning point was Kejriwal’s decision to go on a dharna at Rajpath just outside the Union home ministry, demanding the suspension of five Delhi police officers. At a thirty-two-hour street protest at the venue where the Republic Day parade was to take place in a few days, Kejriwal appeared less like a chief minister and more like a self-styled anarchist. ‘Yes, I am an anarchist,’ he told his supporters, urging them to reach Rajpath. It was an ill-considered remark. For once, his attempt at clever political choreography had let him down. With the images of an elected government clashing with its own police on the streets splashing across the media, Kejriwal’s confrontational politics now signalled political immaturity. Former judge Santosh Hegde termed it ‘pure and simple arrogance of power’.

Slowly, the goodwill began to dissipate and middle-class disenchantment with the AAP leader set in. The television studio, which had once been his ally, became a double-edged sword, subjecting his government to an almost